

Ubuntu is available for download in many forms: Ubuntu Cloud, Ubuntu Core, Ubuntu Kylin, Ubuntu Desktop, and the Ubuntu Server. Ubuntu Desktop is the most commonly used amongst the ones mentioned here. For creating a server, we can either use the traditional Ubuntu Desktop or go with the specialized Ubuntu Server offered. We have to determine when to use what and this article might just be the best guide.

Ubuntu Desktop vs Ubuntu Server

Before we dive in into the comparison of the Ubuntu Desktop and Ubuntu Server, let us focus on the comparison of a desktop and a server. It is a common misconception that a server and a desktop computer are not much different. While it is true that almost any computer meeting the minimum hardware requirements can run a server operating system, it does not make a desktop computer a true server. Even if the desktop computer had identical processor speeds, storage capacity and memory as that of a server, it still isn't a valid replacement. They were engineered for different purposes. They use different technologies.

Moreover, servers often lacks the usual peripherals like the keyboard, mouse, and monitor. A server without peripherals is called a "headless" setup. A desktop, as we know, does include all the peripherals (keyboard, mouse, and monitor). Adding to it, desktop hardware doesn't focus primarily on security, longevity, and stability as it is tuned for general use. So server and desktop hardware lends insight into the divergence of Ubuntu Desktop and Ubuntu Server.

This begs the question, why even consider an ordinary desktop for a server. Well the answer lies in the ease in usage of the desktop compared to a server. For an average Joe, looking for a simple server, an old desktop computer could work just fine. On the other hand, for the small business owners, the question to ask is: What is the server going to be used for? Do you really want to trust your business data and processes to just any old hardware? For basic file servers a small business should choose an operating system that staff will be the most comfortable with and desktops with easy to use GUI easily beats a dedicated server. If your company's data is at all important to you, you will be far satisfied using a dedicated server than a standard desktop computer.

Ubuntu servers occupy 28.46% of the market share, ahead of its competitors and this is for a good reason. The extensible support offered by canonical and the ever helpful Ubuntu community has been a major factor